

The Existential Poker Game

Existentialism (aka Ingmar Bergman, Stanley Kubrick, Jean-Luc Godard – life is absurd and the universe is insane, but we cling on as best we can). It does not matter how good a hand we have been dealt we can never defeat death.

Main theme for actors: Costume Drama (fancy futuristic outfits). Playing around on the banks or the river Wey with a hire boat. Surreal with hints of 'Alice in Wonderland'. The outside shots should be done with iPhones and radio mics and the inside with mixed cameras and boom sound. Actors can play a variety of characters but will need to wear different fancy dress depending on who they are acting.

AI: I am mixing some AI with real actors. Because AI is hopeless with faces, it works better if the hero wears a hoodie (for back views), the nurse wears a mask (for materialising out of thin air scene) and the android female rower wears a Greek Tragedy/Comedy mask for river "events". Like Mary Poppins we could even experiment with a small cartoon scene generated by AI. I use Google Labs for AI (I have paid the subscription). Its not that good at anything over 8 seconds.... Unless we get lucky

I wonder if we can use Mike's green painted garage to shoot the casino scene? Be good if we can.

Between 5 and 7 major-ish parts for actors and numerous minor parts.

I call the star William, but it can just as easily be Williamina...Although women fainting might be considered kind of gauche nowadays so possibly safer to be a man. Existentialism: If David stars as William the plot can be health and fitness guru does everything right but by the random nature of the universe his healthy life does not help to keep him alive.

William and 3 or 4 card players (dressed up in sci-fi outfits – various unsavoury characters – male and female. Queen of Hearts, Mad Hatter, Gangster, Super Rich Play Girl/Boy

Interesting cameo parts: Glamorous female AI Bot rower, croupier and nurse (might be separate people or the same actor – depending on numbers – ideally same person). Security Guard, and Doctor. (possibly AI if not enough volunteers – both can be male or female).

1. Scene One – Marchpane Book shop (Cecil Court London – features in Harry Potter as Diagon Alley – so slightly surreal already).

The STAR and ONE CAMERA PERSON and ME (if I'm not the camera person) go to Waterloo to film. We can have more people if you wish (to check that we get the right footage, technical support).

Returning from a hospital appointment, William walks directly towards the camera. Then we fade to Cecil Court. The shot of the hospital has parliament in the background giving the viewer a vague sense that that this might be a boring NHS and Politics drama. Then we get the back shot of William as he walks into Cecil Court (giving the impression that this alley is directly opposite the hospital and parliament). William Smith: On his way home from a hospital appointment, William passes an unusual book shop. He goes inside. He looks at the Dalek's ray-gun (see image below). He is invited to the dark basement (which in reality is huge and damp). He comes across an old copy of Lewis Carroll (Veronica's old copy). He buys this to read on the train. Camera fades.



2. Scene Two – Back Garden.

William Smith: Once back home William puts the Lewis Carroll novel down on the garden table and begins to read an NHS letter (presumably given to him after his consultation) and promptly collapses in his garden. 15 Seconds. Various camera angles on the book and we glimpse words NHS and Dear Mr.... Take various shots of hero collapsing (if possible) so we don't have to do it again.



3. Scene Three GREEN SCREEN / BUSY HOSPITAL

William Smith: wakes up in a hospital “Where am I...”

Doctor: Enters ward. Nutty Professor type voice (Germanic perhaps). He speaks fast not giving William any time to interject or ask questions.

Doctor: “Hello William I have news for you. You have a very rare condition. The quantum entanglement of your brain’s neurons is not matching the structure of your

heart. The two organs at a subatomic level are out of step. If we don't correct this problem you will die, very soon, within the hour. We have to correct the random fluke."



William Smith: Shocked – wants to speak but can't get the words out.

If we use covid face masks, then AI can generate the glamorous nurse materialising into the ward. The real nurse then, smiles and winks conspiratorially at William.

Otherwise the nurse must walk (AI can't do faces that well).

The nurse: a glamorous nurse walks into the ward, smiles and winks conspiratorially at William.

Doctor: The Doctor offers William a tablet. "This is very new, hush-hush, pre-clinical trial, a temporary fix. It will give you ONE extra hour of life. But there is a cost, your mind", he pauses to think then continues.. " or possibly your body might experience an effect not that dissimilar to time travel".

The Nurse: offers William a glass a water for the tablet and whispers "don't worry it will be fine – drink it"

William Smith: William feels he has no alternative, so he swallows the offered tablet. Just before he passes out, he sees the face of the nurse in close up staring down at him. FADE 1m: 00

4. Scene four – ROWING BOAT NEAR FLYOVER FOOTPATH.

(There are complications with river permissions I should be allowed to film free of charge if we are lucky – but we need the permission)....But if not the boat scene might go... Which is a shame as it's the best!

In the boat we might need radio mics and an iPhone swapped between the AI and William.

William wakes up in a rowing boat with a female AI Bot who reminds William of the nurse in the hospital. She is wearing a Greek style Tragedy/comedy mask. The mask is a good idea because if we do some AI on the river the AI android will look exactly like the actress in a mask. She is dressed in silver. On the side of the boat (perhaps using blue tack) is the word STYX. She wears a lanyard with Persephone written on it.

William is lying on a quilted blanket like in the picture (unlikely but perhaps someone has an unloved old blanket/quilt we can use)



I hope you get the vibe – Greek legends of death and chance...But with pre-Raphaelite sci-fi surreal twists.

William Smith: (wearing a hoodie) Is lying flat in the boat. He slowly wakes up to the sound of someone singing:

AI bot: Singing: “Row, row, row your boat, gently down the stream, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream”.

William: William sees the AI Bot.

William sits up and looks at his phone. 30 minutes have elapsed. William shakes his head in disbelief: “Only 30 minutes left”.

AI Bot: in a no-nonsense flat tone. Emotionless: “I have analysed your condition and as a result you are in this boat”.

William Smith: Confused “What? Then annoyed: “What’s going on?”

AI Bot: Still emotionless “Do not worry, a full cure is available at the “Network” on WEY Island.....”

AI Bot pauses, and thinks, then continues “Well, provided you play their game.”

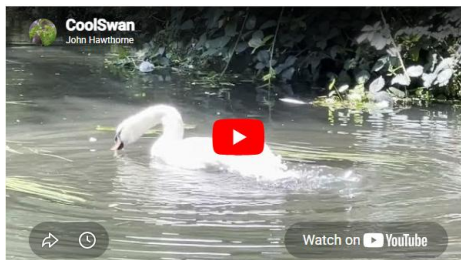
William Smith: Now more confused than ever, but beginning to realise this is not a kidnap it’s a rescue: “What Game?”

AI Bot: Still emotionless “If you want the cure, you will need to win a round of ‘Medical Poker’ “.

AI Existential Waterspout appears and says universe has no meaning.



William Smith: Shakes his head and slowly lays back down while the Bot powerfully and effortlessly rows the boat gently down the stream (life is but a dream). Time for a bit of B roll – like Swans cooling down:



FADE 30 seconds

5. Scene Five – “WEY ISLAND” UNDER THE FLYOVER FOOTPATH

The camera pans down from the futuristic hover cars to the action below the bridge.



William Smith: (wearing a hoodie) William is now fully awake. He jumps out of the boat and ties it to a metal peg on the shore.



A Security Guard comes out of a door in the shadows – along distance away – William, takes the hero's "Long Walk" to his destiny (like in the old gun fighter movies).



The security Guard is wearing pre-Raphaelite clothing (possibly using Jon's hippy wig). The Security Guard blocks William from going further. We could have a small violent tussle between guard and William. Depends on who is acting.

Security Guard: (Possibly in Glasgow Brogue) – holding his right hand out says: "No further Pal. You need to pay the ferryman 200 ZOTS if you want to get in the game".



William Smith: William looks at his phone it now says 40mins. He has only 20 minutes left.

Looking back at the boat, William Smith takes a desperate gamble “ Will you buy the boat? It’s got to be worth 200 ZOTS. “

Security Guard: looks at the boat but he is not impressed. But then his eye catch sight of the Bots laser gun. “tell you what Pal, throw in the gun and the boat and I’ll give you 200 ZOTS”.



William Smith: Nods in agreement as he does so the pillar changes into Kubrak’s 2001 dark black rotating Oblisk.



When the Oblisk stops moving a Victorian door appears embedded in the black graphite pillar.

William walks in leaving the Bot behind (its important that William wears a hoodie as AI cannot do faces and thus only an AI William (in hoodie) will be able to go into the pillar..

Just before the door slams shut:

AI Bot: shouts: “Ask for QuantumSlimVac”



FADE 1m.00

6. Scene six – INSIDE THE MEDICAL POKER GAME

This might work better with various green screens of Smokey gambling dens and we have our table next to the screen.

For real background characters walking past the table, Jon's priest collar is good but also we should have a dressing up box in the casino where we can change into various different costumes and walk past the poker table.

As well as Jon's priest collar, his hippy wig, I have a wizard's hat, a crown and a medical (doctors) costume and I'm sure as a group we have many more.

Some of us should be in Toga's perhaps, waiters, pre-Raphaelites, silver AI-Bots, Greek Masks

Then to double the effect (and more) we add the green screen images generated by AI... To give a sense of a really crowded and vibrant den of iniquity.

Medical Poker: The teams bet money like real poker but whenever they win a hand they get a drug of their choice. Gangsters are here to make money from the desperately ill. This scene will require lots of close up of eyes, (sweating?), Card hands, and guns.

There is a croupier at the door. She is the same person as the rower and the nurse.

Croupier: "What medication do you require?"

William Smith: "QuantumSlimVac" William then goes and sits at a table with four other players (. The Queen of Hearts, the Mad Hatter, the PlayBoy/PlayGirl and a gangster). The other four have laser pistols



Croupier: Walks over to the table and places the tablets on the table. "Good luck everyone" . She shuffles the cards and then deals them out.

William thinks he has a good hand. He bets 20 ZOTS. He looks at his mobile. 50 minutes have gone. Only 10 minutes left.

QUEEN of HEARTS): She looks at her hand. It's a "Full house". She bets 40 ZOTS. Other players fold but William bets another 20 ZOTS to see her hand. He loses and she takes the money and her drug from the table.

QUEEN OF HEARTS: "This is easy" – she carries on playing.

Croupier: "No hands on ray guns" – She waits until they move then she deals.

PLAYBOY: He has four aces. He looks pleased. "Oh boy" he states before betting 50 ZOTS.

William Smith: Looks at his cards and his phone (53 minutes gone). He hopes the player is bluffing. William bets 50 ZOTS. The others fold. The PLAYBOY wins. Its now 55 mins gone.

Croupier: "All hands on the table please" (she looks at William who has his phone under the table looking at the time 57minutes gone).

William: Stumbles out "Sorry" and puts his phone back.

MAD HATTER He has a "Straight flush" – he thinks he has won. He bets 100ZOTS..... The others fold but...

William: He looks at his cards. He knows it must be 59 minutes by now. He bets 100 ZOTs too.

MAD HATTER: Sensing blood bets another 10 ZOTS to finish William off.

William: Bets the extra 10 ZOTS and calls.

MAD HATTER: Places his straight flush on the table. He goes to grab the money and his medication.

TWO ENDINGS TO THE GAME:

William: Says "Wait" and he places his cards down – "It's a Royal Flush". HE WINS! The QUEEN of HEARTS, the MAD HATTER and the GANGSTER all accuse William of cheating. They talk over each other and go for their rayguns. Its now 59minutes and 55seconds.

OR

William: Says "Wait – I'll die without the medication"

The QUEEN of HEARTS, the MAD HATTER and the GANGSTER say "So, you had your chance, you blew it". Its now 59minutes and 55seconds.

William: madly grabs the drugs and bungs the lot into his mouth simultaneously the drug lords fire their ray guns and shoot William – his phone alarm rings, it's an hour....

The croupier has a shocked expression on her face. 2.5 mins

7. Scene seven

William: Continues to lie on the grass. Is he alive or dead? His brilliant hand – the royal flush is strewn across the lawn. The NHS letter and the Lewis Carroll are by the table....



The video ends with the rower singing “Row row, row your boat, gently down the stream, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream